When Wealth Becomes a Moral Dilemma

The Ethics of Charitable Giving Through Giotto's Arena Chapel

By Ashlynn Burgess



Fresco cycle by Giotto, Arena (Scrovegni) Chapel, Padua, c. 1305 • Photo: Steven Zucker, CC BY-NC-SA 2.0 [12]

Giotto's Arena Chapel offers more than an important example of fourteenth-century art. It also provides a window into how wealth, religious devotion, and charitable patronage intersected in medieval Italy. By examining Scrovegni's wealth, the moral ideas represented in Giotto's frescoes, and their connection to modern corporate philanthropy, this article examines how questions about charitable giving and ethical responsibility continue today in modern corporate America.

THE QUESTION BEHIND THE CHAPEL

Wealth, Devotion, and Giving

In fourteenth-century Padua, Enrico Scrovegni, a member of a wealthy family associated with moneylending, commissioned Giotto to decorate what is now known as the Arena Chapel. Inside, the chapel's frescoes unfold across the walls in a carefully ordered cycle of biblical narratives, virtues, vices, judgment, and salvation.[1]

The family's wealth gives this commission an ethical dimension. Medieval Christian teachings did not treat every form of commerce as sinful. Usury, which was the charging of interest on loans, was, however, considered a serious moral concern. Thus, for the Scrovegni family, patronage raised questions about moneylending, repentance, reputation, and the proper use of wealth.[2]

The chapel is more complex than a story of a banker attempting to purchase forgiveness. Scholars have proposed several overlapping motives, including devotion, restitution, social position, and concern for salvation.[2] This complexity makes the chapel useful as a business ethics case because it shows how giving can carry several meanings at once.

Enrico Scrovegni's patronage of the Arena Chapel illustrates how Christian moral expectations influenced the relationship between wealth, religious devotion, and philanthropy in fourteenth-century Italy, offering a historical perspective on ethical earning and charitable giving in modern American corporations.



Giotto, Last Judgment (detail): Enrico Scrovegni presents a model of the Arena Chapel, c. 1305–06.[3]

In Giotto's Last Judgment scene inside the Arena Chapel, Scrovegni himself appears kneeling as he presents a model of the chapel to the Virgin Mary and other holy figures. His placement connects the gift to the chapel's themes of judgment and salvation. It does not prove that the commission was solely an act of atonement, but it makes the relationship between patronage and moral consequences impossible to ignore.[3] To understand why these themes mattered so much, it helps to look more closely at the religious and economic pressures surrounding Scrovegni's wealth.

HISTORICAL LENS

Wealth Under Moral Scrutiny

Scrovegni's relationship with the Cavalieri Gaudenti, a religious order devoted to the Virgin Mary and opposed to usury, places his patronage within a religious setting that questioned the morality of lending and repayment. [4]

That context helps explain why the Scrovegni family's association with moneylending is important to the chapel's imagery. The frescoes can be read as a complex response to Christian ideas about wealth, sin, charity, and salvation rather than as simple evidence of guilt. [2]

These concerns help explain why morality is so visible throughout Giotto's frescoes.

VISUAL ETHICS

Virtue on the Walls



Giotto's personifications of Justice and Injustice in the Arena Chapel.[5]

Giotto's representations of Justice and Injustice connect moral behavior with the well-being of society. Justice presides over an ordered civic world, while Injustice is associated with disorder and violence. [6] the frescoes therefore move ethical questions beyond private devotion and into the health of the community.[6]

The chapel's architecture adds another layer to this interpretation. Giotto's design and frescoes work together as an integrated experience, suggesting that Scrovegni's patronage was not simply a detached donation but a carefully constructed religious and social statement. [7]

Together, these visual and architectural choices show that wealth, morality, and public meaning were closely connected in the chapel. That same relationship creates a useful point of comparison for modern corporate philanthropy.

HISTORICAL-TO-MODERN BRIDGE

The Same Question in a Different World

Although the contexts differ, both the historical and modern cases reveal a recurring tension between the creation of wealth and its later use. They raise questions about how organizations build trust when the way wealth is earned comes under scrutiny. For modern corporations, these questions can affect reputation, stakeholder relationships, and the credibility of philanthropic efforts.

PADUA, ITALY c. 1305	MODERN CORPORATE AMERICA
Commercial wealth	Corporate profit
Religious expectations	Stakeholder expectations
Religious patronage	Corporate philanthropy
Reputation, devotion, restitution	Reputation, responsibility, social impact
How should wealth be used when its method of acquisition is morally scrutinized?	**Can charitable giving be separated from how a company conducts its business?**

The two settings are not equivalent, but both raise questions about how wealth, responsibility, and reputation interact. For modern philanthropy leaders, the comparison highlights how charitable giving is often interpreted within a broader view of organizational conduct. Reputation, trust, and social impact are shaped not only by where money is given, but also by the practices and values associated with how that wealth was created.

MODERN APPLICATION

From Patronage to Corporate Philanthropy

In the U.S., modern corporations operate under very different legal, economic, and religious conditions, but philanthropy still raises questions of reputation and ethical conduct. Research on modern corporate philanthropy shows that firms involved in questionable financial reporting may use giving to rebuild goodwill, but generous donations do not automatically prove either virtue or wrongdoing. [8]

For philanthropy directors, that distinction matters. In practice, a donation can create real community value while also affecting reputation. These effects can coexist without proving what originally motivated the gift.



Modern ethical decision-making visual. Source: ICMA, "Ethics Matter: Be Alert for Conflicts of Interest."[13]

Corporate philanthropy can also have a genuine moral basis beyond financial self-interest, while still supporting a company's standing with stakeholders. [9]



Illustration of charitable giving and global impact. Image: Marcus Butt/Getty Images/Ikon Images, via KPBS. [14]

Together, these perspectives suggest that philanthropy is neither automatic evidence of virtue nor simply reputation management.[8,9] Evaluating a gift also means looking at the broader conduct of the organization behind it.

Philanthropy is best understood neither as automatic evidence of virtue nor as mere reputation management.

As corporate philanthropy has grown, so has its visibility to stakeholders. Looking at the scale of that growth helps explain why questions about how companies give, and how they conduct business, matter to philanthropy leaders today.

FIGURE 1

Corporate Philanthropy Has Grown Significantly

Corporate giving has increased substantially over the past twenty-five years, making philanthropy a more visible part of corporate strategy and stakeholder expectations. Figure 1 shows the scale of that growth and provides context for why questions about the purpose and ethical meaning of corporate giving matter today.

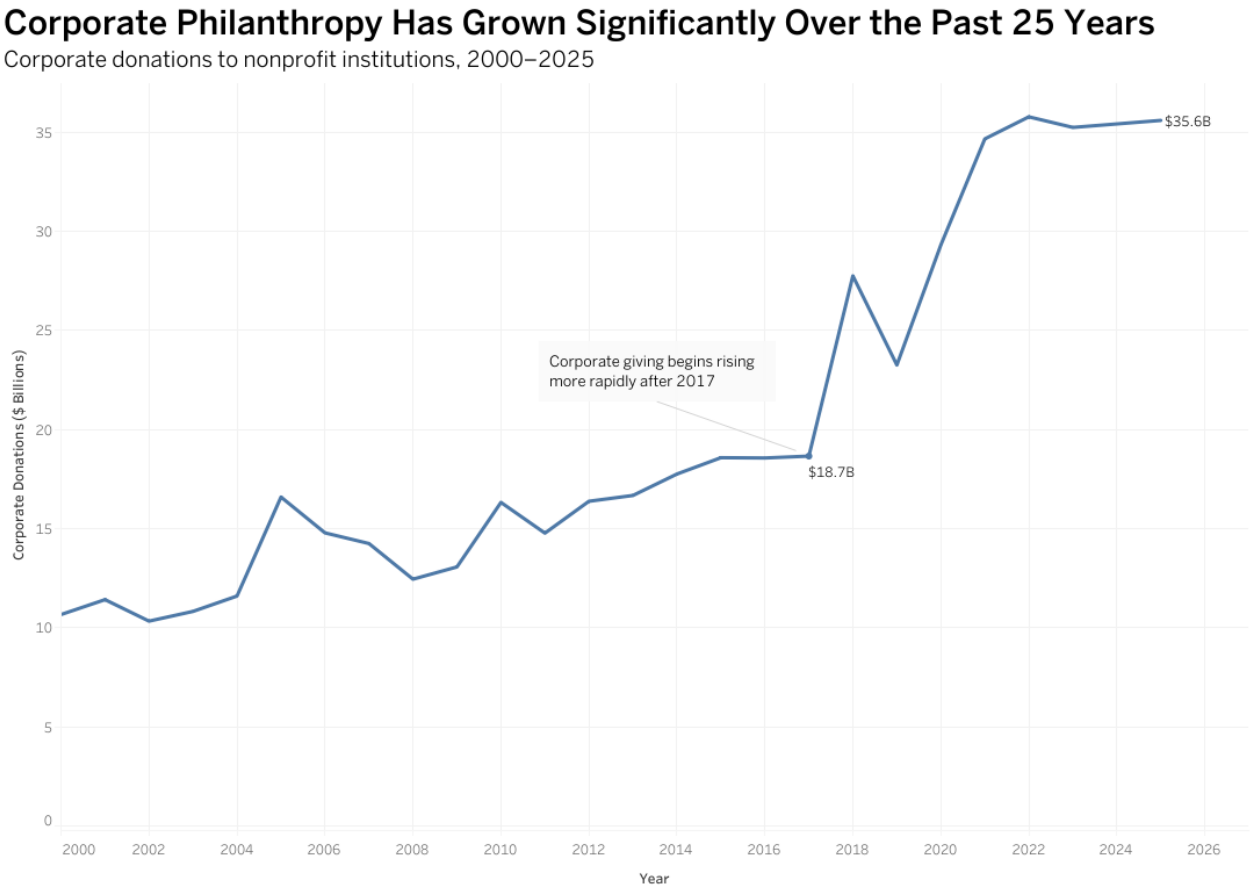


Figure 1. Corporate donations to nonprofit institutions, 2000–2025. Source: U.S. Bureau of Economic Analysis via FRED. Visualization created by the author.[10]

Figure 1 shows that corporate donations to nonprofit institutions rose substantially over the past twenty-five years, reaching about $35.6 billion in 2025. [10] The growth demonstrates the increasing scale and visibility of corporate philanthropy. As giving becomes a larger part of corporate activity, philanthropy leaders can consider not only where resources are directed, but also how those decisions reflect broader organizational values and conduct.

FIGURE 2

Americans View Ethics as Essential in Business Leadership

If corporate philanthropy is evaluated within a broader ethical context, leadership expectations matter too. Figure 2 shows that Americans place greater importance on honesty and ethical conduct than on several other qualities associated with top business executives.

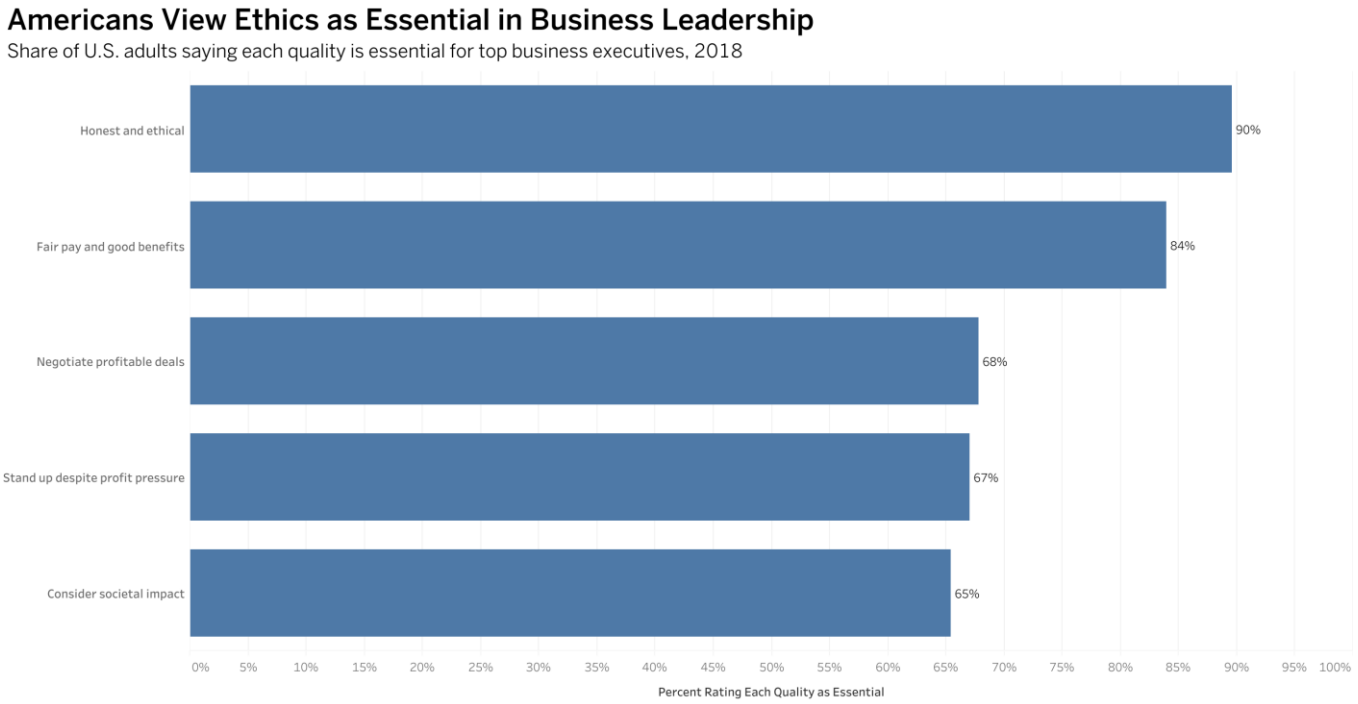


Figure 2. Share of U.S. adults rating selected qualities as essential for top business executives. Source: Pew Research Center, American Trends Panel Wave 36. Visualization created by the author.[11]

Figure 2 shows that 90% of U.S. adults rated honesty and ethical conduct as essential for top business executives, compared with 68% who said the same of negotiating profitable deals. [11] Although the survey does not measure philanthropy directly, it suggests that U.S. adults evaluate business leadership through a broader ethical lens than financial performance alone. That leads back to the article's central point that charitable giving may shape reputation and community impact, but its meaning is also influenced by the conduct and values of the organization behind it. This broader perspective leads back to the Arena Chapel and what its historical example can still teach modern philanthropy leaders.

CLOSING PERSPECTIVE

A Historical Lens for Modern Giving

The Arena Chapel does not provide a medieval formula for modern corporate philanthropy, but it does offer a useful comparison and a change for personal reflection. Scrovegni's patronage shows how wealth, reputation, moral expectations, and giving can be closely connected.

For modern philanthropy professionals, the lesson is not that medieval patronage and corporate giving are the same. It is that charitable giving is often judged alongside the conduct of the organization behind it. As corporate philanthropy grows, that connection between how wealth is earned and how it is given remains worth considering.



Exterior of the Arena (Scrovegni) Chapel, Padua, Italy. [15]

SOURCES

Notes

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AI DISCLOSURE

This article was drafted and revised with assistance from generative AI tools, including ChatGPT, which supported brainstorming, organization, formatting, and sentence-level editing. All final content and sources were reviewed and verified by the author.

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Ashlynn Burgess is an Information Systems student at the BYU Marriott School of Business with interests in philanthropy, business ethics, and using technology and business skills to support meaningful community impact. Her service experience includes coordinating support for families on the Hopi Reservation and mentoring students through BYU MAPS. She hopes to continue applying her business education to philanthropic and community-focused work throughout her career.

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